The diehards on our side have a strong counter-argument: whereas at the beginning of the occupation, in the late 1960s and early 1970s, the Palestinian population did not cause major problems, this changed with the birth of Fatah and, more radically so, with the creation of Hamas (by Israel! in order to create a religious opposition to Fatah), with its lethal mixture of Palestinian nationalism and intense Islamic faith. The demonstration of this dangerous escalation came with Ariel Sharon's decision in 2004 to evacuate the Gaza Strip. Gaza first came under Fatah rule but, following local elections, Hamas took over, swept Fatah away, and has since instigated three wars with Israel, plus endless incidents. The obvious argument of our diehards is that any evacuation of the West Bank would be a repeat of the Gaza situation, with Hamas taking over the territory and their armed militias soon shooting at close range from their newly acquired Palestinian state at the most populous areas of Israel.

The answer to this is that peace means taking risks, probably with outside help: a demilitarized Palestinian state for years with some American presence on its territory, if necessary, and other pre-emptive measures of the same kind. If the Palestinians reject this kind of solution, then tension-lowering steps are the only way forward, for as long as it takes.

Nothing good can come out of Moshe Dayan's famous exhortation of 1953, on the tomb of a friend killed by a Palestinian infiltrator from the Gaza Strip ("Do not fear, brother Yaakov …"), and his vision of Israelis constantly living by the sword.

## *Sunday, January 29*

Yesterday, Avihu Zakai, a former professor of history at Hebrew University, sent me the following quote from Jacob Talmon, the well-known, long-deceased Israeli historian of *The Origins of Totalitarian Democracy*: